

By **Makarand R. Paranjape**

The author is Professor of English at Jawaharlal Nehru University. His latest book is JNU: Nationalism and India's Uncivil War. *Views are personal*

Might is Right in Campus Politics

To stand up against divisive forces, our youth need knowledge as well as understanding. Both, currently, seem to be in short supply

Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), which many regard as both microcosm and barometer, affords an opportune insight into India's larger body politic. On April 10, clashes broke out in Kaveri hostel over the serving of meat on Ramnavami and the obstruction of a *havan* (religious ceremony)—depending on whose version you are listening to. A few days later, on April 13, an outfit called Hindu Sena pasted posters and saffron banners outside the campus. The posters said "Bhagwa JNU" or saffron JNU. Vishnu Gupta, the president of Hindu Sena, claimed that *bhagwa* and Hindutva were insulted on the JNU campus: "Saffron is our culture...in the entire country, not just in Jawaharlal Nehru University." Those who didn't like it were "anti-national" and welcome to leave the country.

What is going on? The first thing to realise is that the JNU scuffle was not communal or religious, in the sense of being a Hindu-Muslim clash. It was ideological and political. A fight between the traditionally dominant Left and the emergent Right, led by the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP), over control of the campus. The Hindu Sena, purportedly of the same "Sangh Parivar", went a step farther, making ABVP look milder, more acceptable, in comparison.

The swift steps by the police against Hindu Sena indirectly implied that no action would be taken against the ABVP, although an FIR had been registered against its cadres. This inference is strengthened by the counter-FIR lodged by the ABVP against the leftist students. The two would probably cancel each other so that no one would be brought to book.

But the message was loud and clear. The takeover of the JNU campus is imminent if not already effected. The Left's last bastion in campus politics has fallen. Just like a fort in medieval India recaptured from enemy hands.

Thence to the Ramnavami and Hanuman Jayanti violence in the rest of India. Is it a coincidence that riots broke out on the same day in different parts of the country along similar lines—*shobha yatra*s or processions being taken out and attacked by Muslim mobs?

Processions before mosques, retaliations over cow killings, alleged burnings or desecrations of holy books—these and several similar provocations were the stock-in-trade of communal riots in colonial India. That they are being revived and deployed should not entirely surprise, even if it certainly saddens, us.

The "blasphemy" incidents over the Sikh sacred book, the Guru Granth Sahib, in Punjab, the killings in gurdwaras, including Shri Harmandir Sahib itself, the holiest of the Sikh holies, in retaliation against sacrilege, exemplify how easy it is to incite religious violence in India. Has anyone been punished for these acts of culpable violence?

Dial a riot, then return the call by massaging the message? Is that the formula in this new round of communal flare-ups in India? Anyone with even a modicum of common sense can be reasonably certain that there is no such thing as

